Introduction

Background

Seventy years after its independence Pakistan's struggle with democracy continues. The country achieved its first democratic transition during the elections of 2013, as the elected government of the Pakistan Peoples Party (PPP) handed over power to the PML(N). PML(N)'s rule was not without controversy. Politically, the biggest blow to the PML(N) was the dismissal of the elected prime minister Nawaz Sharif by the Supreme Court of Pakistan on charges of corruption in connection with the Panamagate scandal[1] in 2017.[2] However, the country faced its biggest tragedy in recent history when the Army Public School (APS) Peshawar was attacked by the Tehrik-i-Taliban Pakistan (TTP) in December 2014; 140 people were killed, 132 of whom were children (Boone 2015). This resulted in a public outcry demanding that the government take action against all extremist groups. The Sharif-led government developed a twenty-point National Action Plan (NAP) that included lifting the 2008 moratorium on the death penalty. The twenty-first constitutional amendment passed on 6 January 2015; it empowered special anti-terrorism courts to try all terrorism suspects including civilians, bypassing the normal justice system. Yet the majority of the executions since the lifting of the moratorium have had nothing to do with terrorism and seem only to have reduced the number of convicts on death row (Justice Project Pakistan 2017). Other parallel structures created (such as the provincial apex committees) have allowed the military to play a more direct role in governance and further marginalize civilian institutions in the name of counterterrorism.

In the midst of the wave of violence that has refused to abate, the state felt the need for a national narrative on countering terrorism. This narrative is promoted through the National Counter Extremism Policy Guidelines (NCEPG) with implementable principles for every citizen and institution in the country to reduce the support, felt by some, for acts of terror. To further demonstrate its earnestness towards fighting terrorism the federal state launched a 'Paigham-i-Pakistan'